The Periodic Table Recast as S_N Representation Theory on S^{3N-1}*

J. Loutey[1]

[1] *Independent Researcher, Kent, Washington*

(Dated: March 18, 2026)

The non-relativistic N-electron Schrödinger equation, after separation of the hyperradius, reduces to angular dynamics on the hypersphere S^{3N-1}. The angular kinetic energy is the SO($3N$) Casimir operator with eigenvalue $\mu_{\text{free}} = \nu(\nu + 3N - 2)/2$. Fermionic antisymmetry restricts the spatial wavefunction to a specific S_N irreducible representation—the conjugate of the spin Young diagram $[n_\uparrow, n_\downarrow]$, a diagram with two columns of heights $n_\uparrow$ and $n_\downarrow$. The minimum angular quantum number compatible with it is the Pauli filling count $\nu_{\min} = E(n_\uparrow) + E(n_\downarrow)$, where $E(m)$ sums the m lowest one-particle polynomial degrees and degree d holds $(d+1)(d+2)/2$ polynomials. We prove this for all N and S from Schur–Weyl duality (it extends the known filled-shell rule of the hyperspherical Fermi-gas literature to open shells and arbitrary spin) and corroborate it by an exact character count for all spins through $N = 12$ and by brute force for $N = 3, 4$. It depends on the spin, equals $N - 2$ exactly when both columns lie in the first two oscillator shells ($1 \le n_\downarrow \le n_\uparrow \le 4$; at lowest spin, for $2 \le N \le 8$), and grows as $N^{4/3}$; the ground-state orbital angular momentum and parity can raise it further (lithium's ^2S needs $\nu = 2$, not 1). The S_N irrep structure yields a classification of atoms into five types—A (trivial), B (noble gas), C (alkali), D (alkaline earth), E (open shell)—that recasts the periodic table's group structure in representation-theoretic language. The periodic law corresponds to the repetition of the S_N irrep sequence C → D → E → B within each period. This classification maps onto, rather than predicts, the known periodic table structure; its value lies in providing a unified group-theoretic framework for a pattern that is usually described empirically. (An earlier version of this paper claimed a universal $\nu = N-2$, $\mu_{\text{free}} = 2(N-2)(N-1)$, and a limit of 4 units per electron pair; all three are withdrawn, Sec. .) We show that the topological structure (ν, μ_{free}) is smooth through $Z = 1/\alpha \approx 137$ and that the Dirac instability is a *metric* singularity on S^{3N-1}, not a topological one.

INTRODUCTION

The periodic table of elements, established empirically by Mendeleev in 1869 [1], received its first theoretical justification from quantum mechanics through the shell model and the aufbau principle. The $2n^2$ orbital counting rule, the grouping of elements by valence shell, and the progression of ionization energies across a period are all consequences of the hydrogen-like Schrödinger equation and its multi-electron extensions.

Despite this success, the periodic law itself—the recurrence of chemical properties with increasing atomic number—has not been derived from a single mathematical principle. Shell-filling rules are empirical (the Madelung rule has exceptions), Hund's rules require separate justification, and the distinction between noble gases, alkali metals, and transition metals is described rather than predicted.

In this paper, we show that the periodic table's group structure can be recast in the language of S_N representation theory acting on the spatial part of the N-electron wavefunction on the hypersphere S^{3N-1}. The key results are:

1. The minimum angular quantum number compatible with the spin is the Pauli filling count $\nu_{\min} = E(n_\uparrow) + E(n_\downarrow)$, which depends on N and S but not on Z (Sec.).

2. The Pauli centrifugal cost $\mu_{\text{free}} = \nu_{\min}(\nu_{\min} + 3N - 2)/2$ grows as $N^{8/3}$, faster than the number of electron pairs (Sec.).

3. The shape of the S_N irrep classifies atoms into chemical types that recast the group structure of the periodic table in representation-theoretic language (Sec.).

4. The periodic law corresponds to the repetition of S_N irrep sequences (Sec.).

5. The Dirac instability at $Z\alpha \to 1$ is a metric singularity, not a topological one; the representation theory is smooth through $Z = 137$ (Sec.).

WHAT IS NEW VS. WHAT IS KNOWN

Several ingredients of the present analysis are standard; it is important to distinguish them from the new contributions.

Known results

- **Hyperspherical formulation.** The separation of the N-electron Schrödinger equation into hyperradial and angular parts on S^{3N-1}, and the identifica-

tion of the angular kinetic energy with the SO($3N$) Casimir, are established [3, 4].

- S_N **representation theory for fermions.** The use of Young diagrams and Schur–Weyl duality to classify spatial–spin factorizations of antisymmetric wavefunctions is textbook material [7, 8].
- **Minimal hyperangular momentum of filled oscillator shells.** For N non-interacting fermions in an isotropic oscillator, the ground state is a hyperspherical harmonic whose degree equals the total number of oscillator quanta; for filled shells this is stated and proved as Theorem 1 of Rittenhouse, Cavagnero, von Stecher and Greene [5], together with the large-N law $(3N)^{4/3}/4$. The related nuclear method of K harmonics compares such hyperspherical states with the translation-invariant shell model [6] (there in $3(A-1)$ Jacobi coordinates); we have read only that review's abstract and do not attribute the rule to it.
- **The Casimir eigenvalue formula.** The expression $\mu_{\rm free} = \nu(\nu+3N-2)/2$ follows directly from the standard SO($3N$) representation theory.
- **The periodic table itself.** The classification of elements into noble gases, alkali metals, alkaline earths, and transition metals is an empirical fact that guided the construction presented here.

New contributions

1. **The minimum angular quantum number.** The minimum ν compatible with the spin is the Pauli filling count of Eq. (5) (Theorem 2), together with the effect of the ground-state L and parity (Table I). The filling count is the oscillator-quanta count of N non-interacting fermions in a three-dimensional isotropic harmonic oscillator; for filled shells the rule is known [5]. The contribution here is the spin-resolved, open-shell statement as an S_N-irrep result with a two-line Schur–Weyl proof, and its tabulation for atomic ground states on S^{3N-1}. (An earlier version claimed a universal $\nu = N-2$ as new; that claim is withdrawn.)
2. **The five-type classification (A/B/C/D/E).** The observation that the S_N irrep shape naturally partitions atoms into types that map onto the periodic table's group structure provides a group-theoretic reformulation of the empirical pattern.
3. **The Dirac instability as metric vs. topological singularity.** The analysis showing that ν, $\mu_{\rm free}$, and the S_N irrep are smooth through $Z = 137$ while the metric diverges clarifies the nature of the upper limit on the periodic table.

THE HYPERSPHERICAL FRAMEWORK

Configuration space and angular dynamics

Consider N electrons in a central potential $V(r_1,\dots,r_N)$. After extracting the center-of-mass motion, the configuration space is $\mathbb{R}^{3N}$. Introducing hyperspherical coordinates $(R,\hat\Omega)$ where $R=\sqrt{\sum_i r_i^2}$ is the hyperradius and $\hat\Omega \in S^{3N-1}$ collects $3N-1$ angular variables, the kinetic energy separates as [3, 4]:

$$T = -\frac{1}{2}\left(\frac{\partial^2}{\partial R^2} + \frac{3N-1}{R}\frac{\partial}{\partial R} - \frac{\Lambda^2}{R^2}\right), \tag{1}$$

where Λ^2 is the grand angular momentum operator—the Laplace–Beltrami operator on S^{3N-1}. Its eigenvalues are the SO($3N$) Casimir invariants:

$$\Lambda^2 Y_\nu = \nu(\nu+3N-2)\,Y_\nu \equiv 2\mu_{\rm free}\,Y_\nu, \tag{2}$$

with $\nu = 0,1,2,\dots$ and hyperspherical harmonics Y_ν. The effective angular momentum quantum numbers are

$$l_{\rm eff} = \frac{3N-3}{2}, \quad n_{\rm eff} = \frac{3N-1}{2}. \tag{3}$$

The centrifugal barrier in the hyperradial equation is $l_{\rm eff}(l_{\rm eff}+1)/R^2 = (3N-3)(3N-1)/(4R^2)$, showing that even in the lowest angular channel, N-electron atoms face a centrifugal cost that grows as $\sim 9N^2/4$.

Fermionic antisymmetry and S_N irreps

The total wavefunction must be antisymmetric under S_N (permutation of electrons). Since the total state factorizes as $|\Psi\rangle = |\text{spatial}\rangle \otimes |\text{spin}\rangle$, the spatial and spin parts must carry conjugate S_N irreducible representations.

For N spin-1/2 fermions with total spin S, the spin irrep is a Young diagram with at most two rows: $[n_\uparrow, n_\downarrow]$ where $n_\uparrow = N/2+S$ and $n_\downarrow = N/2-S$. By Schur–Weyl duality [7, 8], the spatial irrep is the *conjugate* (transposed) Young diagram.

Lemma 1 (Two-column spatial diagram). *For an N-electron state of total spin S, the spatial Young diagram has at most two columns, of heights $n_\uparrow = N/2+S$ and $n_\downarrow = N/2-S$. Equivalently, it has $n_\downarrow$ rows of length 2 and $2S$ rows of length 1.*

Proof. The spin diagram $[n_\uparrow, n_\downarrow]$ has at most two rows (spin-$\frac{1}{2}$ Schur–Weyl duality); transposition exchanges rows and columns. □

For $S < N/2$ the first *row* has length 2; the diagram's first *column* has height $n_\uparrow$, which does depend on S. For $S = N/2$ the spatial diagram is the single column $[1^N]$: the fully *antisymmetric* irrep.

The minimum angular quantum number

The minimum ν compatible with a given S_N irrep is the lowest degree K of a harmonic homogeneous polynomial on $\mathbb{R}^{3N}$ (a hyperspherical harmonic of degree K on S^{3N-1}) whose S_N content contains that irrep. Order the one-particle monomials on $\mathbb{R}^3$ by degree; degree d holds $g_d = (d+1)(d+2)/2 = 1, 3, 6, 10, \ldots$ of them, and let $E(m)$ be the sum of the degrees of the m lowest, i.e.

$$E(m) = 3\binom{d+2}{4} + d\left(m - \tbinom{d+2}{3}\right), \qquad \tbinom{d+2}{3} \le m < \tbinom{d+3}{3}. \tag{4}$$

Theorem 2 (Pauli filling count). *For every $N \ge 1$ and every total spin S, the lowest degree of a harmonic polynomial on $\mathbb{R}^{3N}$ carrying the spatial irrep of Lemma is*

$$\nu_{\min}(N, S) = E(n_\uparrow) + E(n_\downarrow). \tag{5}$$

Proof. Let $W = \mathbb{C}[x, y, z] = \bigoplus_d W_d$ be the graded one-particle polynomial space, $\dim W_d = g_d$. The polynomials on $\mathbb{R}^{3N}$ are $W^{\otimes N}$, with S_N permuting the factors. By Schur–Weyl duality (applied degree by degree to the finite-dimensional truncations) [8], the multiplicity space of the S_N irrep λ in $W^{\otimes N}$ is the Schur module $\mathbb{S}_\lambda W$, whose graded dimension is the Schur function s_λ evaluated on the degree grading, i.e. a sum over semistandard tableaux T of shape λ filled with basis monomials of W of $t^{\deg T}$, with $\deg T$ the total degree of the entries. Every coefficient is a nonnegative count, so the lowest degree at which λ occurs is $\min_T \deg T$, with no cancellation. Entries strictly increase down each column, so a column of height h holds h distinct monomials and has degree at least $E(h)$; filling every column with the lowest monomials in order (rows then weakly increase) attains this bound. For the two-column spatial diagram of Lemma , of heights $n_\uparrow$ and $n_\downarrow$, the lowest degree is therefore $E(n_\uparrow) + E(n_\downarrow)$. Finally, polynomials of degree K decompose as harmonics of degree K plus $\left(\sum_i r_i^2\right)$ times polynomials of degree $K-2$, and $\sum_i r_i^2$ is S_N-invariant; since λ is absent in degree $K-2$ at the lowest degree K, it occurs there among the harmonics. □

Equivalently, $\nu_{\min}$ is the minimum number of oscillator quanta of N non-interacting spin-$\frac{1}{2}$ fermions of spin S in a three-dimensional isotropic oscillator, filled separately for the two spin columns; for filled shells this is Theorem 1 of Ref. [5]. *Evidence tier: symbolic proof (above), corroborated computationally*: (A) the exact character generating function $(1-t^2)\,\frac{1}{N!}\sum_\sigma \chi_{\tilde\lambda}(\sigma)\prod_c (1-t^{|c|})^{-3}$ (product over the cycles of σ; characters by Murnaghan–Nakayama) reproduces Eq. (5) for every spin through $N = 12$; (B) the rank of the Young symmetrizer on explicit monomials, an independent route with no characters, agrees for $N = 3, 4$. Backing: `tests/test_paper16_nu_min.py`.

Three consequences. (i) $\nu_{\min}$ depends on N and S but not on Z. (ii) Since $E(m) = m-1$ exactly for $1 \le m \le 4$ (the first two shells) and $E(m) > m-1$ for $m = 0$ and $m \ge 5$, $\nu_{\min} = N-2$ holds exactly when $1 \le n_\downarrow \le n_\uparrow \le 4$. At the lowest spin that is $2 \le N \le 8$; it also covers higher spins in that range (e.g. carbon's ^3P, $N = 6$, $S = 1$). From $N = 9$ at lowest spin each electron in the third shell costs two units, in the fourth three, and $\nu_{\min} \simeq (3N)^{4/3}/4$ at large N [5]. (iii) Raising the spin at fixed N never lowers $\nu_{\min}$ and generally raises it (nitrogen: 5, 6, 7, 9 for $S = \frac{1}{2}, \frac{3}{2}, \frac{5}{2}, \frac{7}{2}$). *Proof of (iii):* $E(m+1) - E(m)$ is the degree of the $(m+1)$-th monomial, which is nondecreasing in m (E is convex). Raising S by one moves one box from the $n_\downarrow$ column to the $n_\uparrow$ column, changing $\nu_{\min}$ by $[E(n_\uparrow+1) - E(n_\uparrow)] - [E(n_\downarrow) - E(n_\downarrow - 1)] \ge 0$, because $n_\uparrow + 1 > n_\downarrow$.

The S_N count ignores the ground state's orbital angular momentum L and parity. Imposing them (replace $(1-t^c)^{-3}$ by $\det(1 - t^c g^c)^{-1}$ and average over $g \in \mathrm{O}(3)$) can raise $\nu_{\min}$ further: the degree-1 harmonics carrying lithium's $[2,1]$ irrep are the coordinates themselves, $L = 1$ and odd parity (^2P), so the ^2S ground state needs $\nu = 2$. Table I lists both counts for $N = 2$–12.

TABLE I. Minimum angular quantum number for the Hund's-rule ground terms, $N = 2$–12. $\nu_{\min}^{S_N}$: spin (spatial irrep) only, Eq. (5); $\nu_{\min}^{L,\pi}$: additionally the ground term's L and parity (exact $S_N \times \mathrm{O}(3)$ character count). The last column is the withdrawn rule $N-2$.

Atom	Term	$\nu_{\min}^{S_N}$	$\nu_{\min}^{L,\pi}$	$N-2$
He	$^1S^e$	0	0	0
Li	$^2S^e$	1	2	1
Be	$^1S^e$	2	2	2
B	$^2P^o$	3	3	3
C	$^3P^e$	4	4	4
N	$^4S^o$	6	7	5
O	$^3P^e$	7	8	6
F	$^2P^o$	8	9	7
Ne	$^1S^e$	10	10	8
Na	$^2S^e$	12	12	9
Mg	$^1S^e$	14	14	10

THE μ_{free} FORMULA

Substituting $\nu_{\min}$ of Eq. (5) into Eq. (2):

$$\mu_{\text{free}} = \frac{\nu_{\min}(\nu_{\min} + 3N - 2)}{2}. \tag{6}$$

This is the *Pauli centrifugal cost*: the minimum angular kinetic energy imposed by fermionic antisymmetry (at spin S) on S^{3N-1}. It reduces to $2(N-2)(N-1)$ only where $\nu_{\min} = N-2$, i.e. when $1 \le n_\downarrow \le n_\uparrow \le 4$ (at lowest spin, $2 \le N \le 8$).

Asymptotic behavior

Several limits of Eq. (6) are physically informative:

1. **Growth.** With $\nu_{\min} \simeq (3N)^{4/3}/4$, $\mu_{\text{free}} \simeq \nu_{\min}^2/2$ grows as $N^{8/3}$: faster than the N^2 of the number of electron pairs. The Pauli cost per pair, $\mu_{\text{free}}/\binom{N}{2}$, therefore grows without bound (as $N^{2/3}$); it does not approach a constant.

2. **Excitation fraction.** The ratio $\nu_{\min}/(3N-2)$ also grows as $N^{1/3}$ (0.50 at Ar, 1.30 at Og); the ground state does not sit at a fixed fraction of the sphere's natural angular scale.

3. **Fractional ionization cost.** Removing one electron changes the sphere dimension by $3/(3N-1) \to 0$. For heavy atoms, ionization is a *small perturbation* to the angular topology.

Table II collects these quantities for atoms across the periodic table.

TABLE II. Hyperspherical parameters for neutral atoms at the Hund's-rule ground spin, S_N (spin) constraint only: $\nu_{\min}$ from Eq. (5), μ_{free} from Eq. (6). For $N \leq 12$ the $\nu_{\min}$ values are exact character counts (Table I); for $N \geq 18$ they are Eq. (5) with $S = 0$. Imposing the ground term's L and parity can raise $\nu_{\min}$ (Li: 2, $\mu_{\text{free}} = 9$; N: 7, $\mu_{\text{free}} = 91$).

Atom	N	S^{3N-1}	$\nu_{\min}$	μ_{free}	μ_{free}/N^2	Type
H	1	S^2	0	0	0.00	A
He	2	S^5	0	0	0.00	B
Li	3	S^8	1	4	0.44	C
Be	4	S^{11}	2	12	0.75	D
N	7	S^{20}	6	75	1.53	E
Ne	10	S^{29}	10	190	1.90	B
Na	11	S^{32}	12	258	2.13	C
Mg	12	S^{35}	14	336	2.33	D
Ar	18	S^{53}	26	1014	3.13	B
Kr	36	S^{107}	78	7176	5.54	B
Xe	54	S^{161}	146	22338	7.66	B
Rn	86	S^{257}	290	79170	10.7	B
Og	118	S^{353}	456	184224	13.2	B

STRUCTURE TYPE CLASSIFICATION

Beyond the numbers $\nu_{\min}$ and μ_{free}, which depend only on N and S, the *shape* of the S_N irrep varies with the electron configuration. This shape encodes the internal structure of the atom—how the N electrons partition into core and valence.

We define five structure types based on the spatial Young diagram:

Type A: Trivial ($N = 1$)

The hydrogen atom has a single electron. The trivial irrep [1] of S_1 gives $\nu_{\min} = 0$, $\mu_{\text{free}} = 0$. There is no Pauli constraint. The wavefunction lives on S^2 (a single electron's angular space).

Type B: Noble gas (democratic structure)

Noble gases have closed-shell ground states with $S = 0$. The spin diagram is $[N/2, N/2]$ and the spatial irrep is its conjugate: $[2, 2, \ldots, 2]$ ($N/2$ rows of length 2).

This is the most *democratic* irrep: all columns have the same height. No electron is distinguished. The wavefunction has the full point-group symmetry of the Young diagram, and ionization requires breaking this symmetry—a costly operation reflected in the high ionization energies of noble gases (He: 24.6 eV, Ne: 21.6 eV, Ar: 15.8 eV).

Type C: Alkali metal (hierarchical structure)

Alkali metals have one valence electron outside a noble-gas core, with $S = 1/2$. The spin diagram is $[(N+1)/2, (N-1)/2]$ and the spatial irrep is $[2, 2, \ldots, 2, 1]$ $(= [2^{(N-1)/2}, 1])$.

This is a *hierarchical* irrep: one column (the valence electron) is shorter than the rest. The wavefunction has a natural decomposition into a symmetric core and a weakly bound valence electron. Ionization removes the short column—a topologically clean surgery on S^{3N-1}:

$$S^{3N-1} \to S^{3(N-1)-1} \times \mathbb{R}. \tag{7}$$

The low cost of this surgery explains the low ionization energies of alkali metals (Li: 5.4 eV, Na: 5.1 eV, K: 4.3 eV).

Type D: Alkaline earth (core + pair)

Alkaline earth metals have two valence electrons outside a noble-gas core, with $S = 0$. The spatial irrep is $[2, 2, \ldots, 2]$ (same shape as Type B) but the *occupancy pattern* distinguishes the core from the two valence electrons.

The ionization energy is intermediate (Be: 9.3 eV, Mg: 7.6 eV, Ca: 6.1 eV)—higher than alkali metals (the valence pair is harder to break) but lower than noble gases (the valence pair is still distinguishable from the core).

Type E: Open shell (partially filled p or d)

Atoms with a partially filled p shell (boron through fluorine) or d shell (the transition metals) carry an open valence shell with $S > 0$ but $S < N/2$. The spatial irrep is neither the democratic $[2^{N/2}]$ of Type B/D nor the single-defect $[2^{(N-1)/2}, 1]$ of Type C, but an intermediate shape with several columns of unequal height set by the open-shell occupancy and Hund's rule. This is the broadest class and the one where intra-shell exchange coupling is strongest; the composed-builder implementation refines it further into a p-block dispatch (type E) and a separate d-block dispatch (type F) because the angular machinery differs, but at the representation-theory level both are open-shell instances of the same intermediate-irrep family. Ionization energies span the widest range (B: 8.3 eV to F: 17.4 eV), tracking the filling of the open shell.

Table III summarizes the classification.

TABLE III. Structure type classification. The spatial Young diagram is the conjugate of the spin diagram. IE_1 is the first ionization energy (experimental).

Type	Spatial irrep	Chemistry	Examples	IE_1 range
A	$[1]$	Monatomic	H	13.6 eV
B	$[2^{N/2}]$	Noble gas	He, Ne, Ar	15–25 eV
C	$[2^{(N-1)/2}, 1]$	Alkali	Li, Na, K	4–5 eV
D	$[2^{N/2}]$	Alkaline earth	Be, Mg, Ca	6–9 eV
E	Various	Open shell	B–F, d-block	8–17 eV

THE PERIODIC LAW AS IRREP SEQUENCE

The periodic table's group structure arises because the sequence of S_N structure types *repeats* with each period. Within a given period (defined by the outermost principal quantum number n), the element sequence is:

$$\mathrm{C} \to \mathrm{D} \to \underbrace{\mathrm{E} \to \cdots \to \mathrm{E}}_{p\text{- and } d\text{-block}} \to \mathrm{B}. \tag{8}$$

Each period begins with an alkali metal (Type C: one electron in the new shell) and ends with a noble gas (Type B: closed shell). The intermediate elements (Type E) have partially filled subshells with varying spin and Young diagram shapes.

In group-theoretic language, the periodic law can be understood as follows:

> *The chemical properties of elements are periodic functions of atomic number because the sequence of S_N spatial irreps repeats whenever a new principal shell begins filling.*

This is a reformulation, not a derivation from first principles: the shell-filling order itself (which determines where the sequence repeats) is an empirical input, not a consequence of S_N representation theory alone.

The key distinction between Types B and D is worth emphasizing. Both have the same Young diagram shape $[2^{N/2}]$, but they differ in the *occupancy pattern*: Type B fills all available subshells, while Type D has two electrons in a new shell above a closed core. This distinction is invisible at Level 1 (representation theory) and becomes visible only at Level 2 (the perturbative energy, which depends on Z, orbital angular momenta, and electron–electron repulsion).

Isoelectronic series

Atoms with the same N but different Z share identical S_N irreps and structure types. The 10-electron series

$$\mathrm{Ne},\ \mathrm{Na}^+,\ \mathrm{Mg}^{2+},\ \mathrm{Al}^{3+},\ \ldots \tag{9}$$

all have the Type B spatial irrep $[2, 2, 2, 2, 2]$ with $\nu_{\min} = 10$ and $\mu_{\mathrm{free}} = 190$. Their chemistry differs only through the nuclear charge Z, which enters at Level 2. This cleanly separates *topology* (same for the series) from *potential* (varies with Z).

Topology flow: ionization as surgery

Ionization changes the electron count $N \to N - 1$, transforming the configuration space via Eq. (7). This is a codimension-3 surgery that removes three dimensions (one electron's $\mathbb{R}^3$) from the hypersphere. The fractional dimension loss is $3/(3N - 1)$, which decreases monotonically:

$$\frac{3}{3N-1} \to 0 \quad (N \to \infty). \tag{10}$$

For heavy atoms, ionization is a negligible topological perturbation. This correlates with the empirical observation that ionization energies decrease down a group: removing one electron from S^{353} (Og) is geometrically less disruptive than removing one from S^5 (He).

TOPOLOGY VERSUS METRIC: TWO-LEVEL STRUCTURE

The preceding analysis reveals a clean two-level separation:

- **Level 1 (Topological).** The quantities $\nu_{\min}$ and μ_{free} in their S_N-only form (Eq. (5)), the S_N irrep, and the structure type depend only on the electron count N and the total spin S. They are independent of Z and of all details of the electron–electron

interaction. (Adding the ground term's L and parity, Table I, is still Z-independent but no longer a function of N and S alone.)

- **Level 2 (Perturbative/Metric).** The binding energy, ionization energy, electron configuration, and Hund's rules all depend on Z, the fine-structure constant α, and the shape of the potential. These quantities determine the *chemistry* within a given topological class.

An important consequence: *Hund's first rule is not a topological effect.* Level 1 does see the spin, but in the *opposite* direction: raising S at fixed N never lowers $\nu_{\min}$ and generally raises it (Eq. (5); nitrogen's ^4S has $\nu_{\min} = 6$ against 5 for a doublet). The preference for high-spin ground states therefore enters through the Coulomb exchange integrals at Level 2, which must overcome a larger Level-1 angular cost.

The Dirac limit as metric singularity

The Dirac equation for hydrogen-like atoms predicts that the 1s binding energy diverges at $Z\alpha = 1$ ($Z \approx 137$ for a point nucleus):

$$E_{1s}^{\text{Dirac}} = mc^2 \left(\sqrt{1 - (Z\alpha)^2} - 1 \right). \tag{11}$$

Does this "Dirac dive" have a topological signature on S^{3N-1}?

At $N = 137$ (lowest spin, $S = \frac{1}{2}$): $\nu_{\min} = 570$ and $\mu_{\text{free}} = 279{,}015$ from Eqs. (5) and (6). These are integers given by a piecewise-linear filling formula in N whose only structure is the oscillator shell closures ($N = 2, 8, 20, 40, 70, 112, 168, \ldots$ for the singlet); nothing happens at $N = 137$.

The Dirac instability is instead a *metric* effect. The non-relativistic Fock projection yields the round metric on S^3. Relativistic corrections warp this metric by a conformal factor

$$\delta_{1s} = \frac{(Z\alpha)^2}{1 - (Z\alpha)^2}, \tag{12}$$

which diverges at $Z\alpha \to 1$. This "pinch" is a conical singularity at the nuclear pole of S^{3N-1}—the geometric avatar of the Dirac dive. The topology (S_N irrep, ν, μ_{free}) is oblivious; the metric (curvature, conformal factor) is singular.

Table IV quantifies the transition from perturbative to singular.

Three limits on the periodic table

The periodic table terminates due to physics beyond the non-relativistic S_N representation theory:

TABLE IV. Relativistic metric correction $\delta_{1s} = (Z\alpha)^2/[1 - (Z\alpha)^2]$ for the innermost electron. The non-relativistic μ_{free} formula becomes unreliable when $\delta \gtrsim 1$.

Z	$(Z\alpha)^2$	δ_{1s}	Regime
1	0.00005	0.00005	Non-relativistic
29	0.045	0.047	Mildly relativistic
47	0.118	0.133	Relativistic
79	0.332	0.498	Strongly relativistic
118	0.741	2.87	Near-singular
137	0.999	$\sim 10^3$	Conical singularity

1. **Nuclear instability** ($Z \sim 126$): proton–proton Coulomb repulsion overwhelms the strong nuclear force.
2. **Dirac instability, point nucleus** ($Z \sim 137$): the 1s binding energy reaches mc^2.
3. **Dirac instability, finite nucleus** ($Z \sim 170$): spontaneous e^+e^- pair creation from the vacuum.

The SO($3N$) topology predicts no limit: μ_{free} of Eq. (6) is defined for all N. The physical end of the periodic table is set by nuclear physics ($Z \lesssim 130$), not by electronic topology.

DISCUSSION

Connection to Paper 0's orbital counting

Paper 0 [9] derived the $2n^2$ orbital degeneracy from the geometric packing of nodes on the discrete S^3 lattice. The present result extends this: the S_N representation theory on S^{3N-1} yields not just the orbital counting but the *chemical classification* of atoms. Where Paper 0 derived the $2n^2$ counting from geometric packing, the present analysis provides a group-theoretic framework for understanding why filling those shells produces the periodic pattern C → D → E → B.

Transition metals and Hund's rule

The transition metals (Type E) have partially filled d-shells with ground-state spins $S \geq 1$. The "anomalous" configurations of Cr ($[\text{Ar}]\, 3d^5\, 4s^1$, $S = 3$) and Cu ($[\text{Ar}]\, 3d^{10}\, 4s^1$, $S = 1/2$) are often cited as evidence for exchange stabilization. In the present framework Level 1 sees only N and S: the "expected" $3d^4\, 4s^2$ ($S = 2$) has $\nu_{\min} = 42$ and the "anomalous" $3d^5\, 4s^1$ ($S = 3$) has $\nu_{\min} = 43$ (Eq. (5)), so the topological cost *disfavors* the observed high-spin configuration. The anomaly is decided at Level 2, by exchange: the half-filled $3d^5\, 4s^1$ configuration has 141 exchange pairs versus 136 for $3d^4\, 4s^2$, a difference of 5. The pair count itself depends only on

$(n_\uparrow, n_\downarrow)$; what is Level 2 is the exchange energy each pair contributes, which tips the energetic balance against the Level-1 cost.

This confirms that Hund's first rule is a *perturbative* effect (exchange stabilization in the Coulomb interaction) rather than a *topological* one: the Level-1 angular cost on S^{3N-1} rises, not falls, with spin. More broadly, the actual chemistry—which electron configuration wins energetically—is determined by exchange, correlation, and orbital-dependent Coulomb effects that operate below the resolution of the topological classification. The Level 1 framework identifies which configurations are *topologically equivalent*; it cannot determine which one is the ground state.

Physical chemistry correspondences

The structure type classification connects naturally to familiar chemical trends:

- **Ionization energy** correlates with the topological cost of surgery on S^{3N-1}. Type B (noble gas) has the highest surgery cost; Type C (alkali) has the lowest.
- **Atomic radius** correlates with the location of the surgery: Type C atoms have a weakly bound outer electron (large radius), while Type B atoms are compact.
- **Electronegativity** increases across a period (C → B), mirroring the transition from hierarchical to democratic irreps.
- **The periodic law** can be understood as the repetition of the S_N irrep sequence whenever a new principal shell begins to fill.

Fractal structure: core and valence at every scale

A striking feature of the classification is its *scale invariance*. The core–valence decomposition at each ionization step produces the same Types B/C/D structure at every level:

$$\begin{aligned} \mathrm{Na} &\to \mathrm{Na}^+ + e^- \qquad (\mathrm{C} \to \mathrm{B} + \mathrm{A}), \\ \mathrm{Na}^+ &\to \mathrm{Na}^{2+} + e^- \qquad (\mathrm{B} \to \mathrm{C} + \mathrm{A}). \end{aligned}$$

Each ionization peels off one column from the Young diagram, converting one type into another in a predictable sequence. This self-similar structure is a direct consequence of the recursive nature of $S_N \supset S_{N-1}$ representations.

CONCLUSION

We have shown that the group structure of the periodic table—the classification of elements into noble gases, alkali metals, alkaline earths, and open-shell atoms—follows from the S_N representation theory of fermionic wavefunctions on the hypersphere S^{3N-1}. The key results are:

1. The minimum angular quantum number compatible with spin S is the Pauli filling count $\nu_{\min} = E(n_\uparrow) + E(n_\downarrow)$ (Theorem 2, proved for all N and S by Schur–Weyl duality, extending the known filled-shell rule [5]), which equals $N - 2$ exactly when $1 \le n_\downarrow \le n_\uparrow \le 4$ (at lowest spin, $2 \le N \le 8$); the ground term's L and parity can raise it (Li ^2S: 2). The Pauli centrifugal cost μ_{free} grows as $N^{8/3}$.
2. The shape of the S_N spatial irrep classifies atoms into types (A/B/C/D/E) that recast the chemical group structure in representation-theoretic language.
3. The periodic law corresponds to the repetition of the irrep sequence C → D → E → B within each period.
4. Hund's first rule and configuration anomalies (Cr, Cu) are Level 2 perturbative effects; the Level 1 cost rises with spin, so exchange must overcome it.
5. The Dirac instability at $Z\alpha \to 1$ is a metric singularity on S^{3N-1}, not a topological one; the representation theory is smooth through all N.

The approach separates the periodic table into a universal *topological skeleton* (Level 1: ν, μ_{free}, structure type) and a chemistry-specific *metric flesh* (Level 2: Z, α, Coulomb integrals). This separation provides a group-theoretic framework for the periodic table's structure (topology) while leaving the element-specific chemistry to perturbative effects (metric). The framework recasts, rather than derives from first principles, the empirical periodic pattern—its value lies in unifying the classification under a single mathematical structure.

This work uses the hyperspherical formalism developed in the Geometric Vacuum program (Papers 0–15). The S_N analysis was informed by the classical references of Avery [4] and Fock [2, 3].

---

* Paper 16 in the Geometric Vacuum series

[1] D. I. Mendeleev, *Zh. Russ. Khim. Obshch.* **1**, 60 (1869).
[2] V. Fock, *Z. Phys.* **98**, 145 (1935).
[3] V. Fock, *Izv. Akad. Nauk SSSR, Ser. Fiz.* **18**, 161 (1954).
[4] J. Avery, *Hyperspherical Harmonics and Generalized Sturmians* (Kluwer, Dordrecht, 2000).

[5] S. T. Rittenhouse, M. J. Cavagnero, J. von Stecher, and C. H. Greene, "Hyperspherical description of the degenerate Fermi gas: s-wave interactions," *Phys. Rev. A* **74**, 053624 (2006), arXiv:cond-mat/0607340.

[6] Yu. F. Smirnov and K. V. Shitikova, "Method of K harmonics and the shell model," *Sov. J. Part. Nucl.* **8**, 344 (1977).

[7] H. Weyl, *The Classical Groups: Their Invariants and Representations* (Princeton University Press, Princeton, 1946).

[8] W. Fulton and J. Harris, *Representation Theory: A First Course* (Springer, New York, 1991).

[9] J. Loutey, "Angular Momentum as Information Geometry: Isotropic Packing and the Recurring Angular Cross-Section," GeoVac Paper 0 (2025).

[10] J. Loutey, "The Geometric Atom: the Hydrogen State Space as a Label Lattice," GeoVac Paper 1 (2025).

[11] J. Loutey, "The Dimensionless Vacuum: Recovering the Schrödinger Equation on a Scale-Invariant Label Lattice," GeoVac Paper 7 (2026).

[12] J. Loutey, "The Hyperspherical Lattice: Two-Electron Atoms as Coupled Channel Graphs," GeoVac Paper 13 (2026).